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Uncanny Communication and the Porous Mind

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In this paper I examine the phenomenon of “uncanny” unconscious communication and the plausibility of “telepathic” interconnectivity between patient and therapist. While reexamining long-standing psychoanalytic reluctance to engage with the topic of the “uncanny,” I present clinical examples of seeming anomalous transmission, followed by discussion from contrasting perspectives of psychoanalysis, neuroscience, quantum physics, and parapsychology. The patient’s and analyst’s reactions to these uncanny moments are explored, along with the potential clinical value of nurturing receptivity to this “frequency” of unconscious attunement.

“Perhaps the only limits to the human mind are those we believe in.”

Willis Harman (1988)

President of the Institute of Noetic Sciences, 1977–1997

Can two minds share the same thoughts without physical or material interaction? Can information be “known” or “transmitted” between people without the exchange of sensory data? “Uncanny”¹ transmissions are unbidden. They penetrate our Newtonian-based rational world, stretching accepted material parameters of human communication to engage with the possibility of “Psi”² and “paranormal”³ phenomena.”

This paper engages the controversy between Western scientifically based skepticism and the growing body of evidence supporting the existence of uncanny phenomena in human nonverbal communication. Freud’s (1901) earliest interest in “thought transference”/“telepathy”⁴ calls for reinstatement as contemporary psychoanalysts grapple with theories of the “bi-personal

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¹ “Uncanny” signifies mysterious, unfamiliar, eerie. I use the terms *uncanny/anomalous* teamed with *cognition/transmission* interchangeably to signify telepathy, thought transference, and all forms of nonmaterial mind-to-mind communication. Connotations vary based on their sociohistorical context ranging from mystical to scientific. This paper predominantly uses the terms *uncanny* and *telepathic* based on Freud’s (1921) original usage.

² The term “Psi” (first used by Thouless in 1942) refers to psychic experiences ranging from *clairvoyance* (knowledge of distant events), to *precognition* (knowledge of the future), *telepathy* (communication through means other than sensory perception), and *psychokinesis* (mind over matter). Psi is defined as “the means by which information can be gained from a distance without the use of the ordinary senses” (Radin, 2006, p. 284).

³ The term “paranormal” (signifying not scientifically explainable) was adopted in the 1930s by J. B. Rhine.

⁴ “Telepathy,” from the ancient Greek *tele* meaning “distant” and *patheia* meaning “feeling, perception”—coined by Frederic W.H. Myers in 1882—is defined in the *Collins English Dictionary* as “the communication between people of thoughts, feelings, desires, etc., involving mechanisms that cannot be understood in terms of known scientific laws.”

unconscious field” (Baranger & Baranger, 2008; Civitaresse & Ferro, 2013; Ferro, 2006, 2009; Stern, 2013; Stolorow, Atwood, & Ross, 1978), the “relational unconscious” (Gerson, 2004), neuropsychological research on empathy (Gallese, 2007; Mancina, 2006), the exchange of “mirror neurons” (Gallese, 2009), the intergenerational transmission of trauma (Fraiberg, Adelson, & Shapiro, 1975), and the “porousness/permeability of mind” (Allik, 2003; Bass, 2001; Bromberg, 1999; Harris, 2004a; Schore, 2001), all of which represent unconscious interconnectedness. The time is ripe to reopen the subject of telepathy and the canonical resistance it has heretofore received in our field.

Drawing on a sequence of uncanny events that occurred in my own clinical work, I show how telepathy can serve as a plausible vehicle of nonverbal communication. Interdisciplinary evidence culled from psychoanalysis, neuroscience, parapsychology, and quantum physics redefine these anomalous communications, beginning with scrutiny of a “slip of the tongue” (my own) that seemingly ushered in otherwise unknowable information about my patient Jordan. I then examine important clinical implications of uncanny transmissions, keeping in mind that this phenomenon probably occurs more frequently than is realized.

SLIP OF THE TONGUE

In the spring of 2009, an unbidden word popped out of my mouth during a session with Jordan, and I had no idea how this slip would change the direction of Jordan’s treatment and my career as a psychoanalyst.

Jordan entered my New York office looking harried and agitated, agonizing over a decision about whether to leave her husband for a week to go on a long-desired photography retreat in Santa Fe. She had become enmeshed with her husband, George, barely leaving his bedside since he had become chronically ill many months earlier. Now that George was fully recovered, Jordan was at last free to pursue her own creative desire, yet she was stalling. The concept of embracing her own passionate interest in photography while remaining connected to the security of relationship(s) at home was new to Jordan.

Our 18-month-long analytic relationship had been hard-won. Relationships in Jordan’s life had often ended unpredictably and irreversibly. Jordan had begun treatment angry and critical, occasionally storming out of my office in outrage, and repairs between us had been arduous though tender. She would easily become emotionally flooded in sessions, requiring careful empathic attunement, my own honest self-assessment, and frequent affect regulation. Details, such as names, dates, or unnecessary narrative facts, were rarely discussed, and we had never discussed the location of where she had grown up. Our dialogue, usually highly affectively charged, would center in the transference–countertransference action.

Having grown up in a family of physical violence coupled with emotional neglect, Jordan had been repeatedly blamed for her older brother’s violent attacks and left alone to process unregulatable fear, rage, and helplessness. As we discussed her wish to go on the Santa Fe trip, memories resurfaced of barricading herself behind her bedroom door after school to fend off her brother’s brutal attacks while her parents were still at work. Never feeling safe in her own home, after school Jordan would escape to the safety of her friend Alicia’s house in the next town, where she would “hang out” until it was safe enough to venture back into her own house.

Jordan was insisting that she could not go on the trip to Santa Fe: She would not leave George for the week, despite the fact that he was encouraging her to go. I felt my frustration mounting. She had coveted this photographic retreat for many months, had worked hard on themes of self-differentiation, yet was now about to succumb to old, self-destructive, relational patterns. She bemoaned that she just couldn't do it! Santa Fe was just too far away.

"It's not about the *geography*!" I finally declared. "You could always text or Skype with him from there. ... You could be in ... *Tuckahoe* for that matter, and still talk it through with him!" ("Tuckahoe?" I asked myself. "Where did *that* name come from? I meant to say 'Timbuktu.'")

She turned away, and with a curl of her lip she said, "How did you know that's where Alicia lived? Tuckahoe's the name of the town I've been talking about here for the past half hour—the one where I'd go hang out after school with Alicia."

I felt a strange loosening in my body, as if floating inside my skin. I told her I had never heard of Tuckahoe and had no idea why it had popped out of my mouth. "Okay ... so what do you make of me coming up with that name?" I ventured.

"Oh, nothing new," she said. "That sort of thing happens to me all the time. ... People just *know* things ... and I just *know* things about people...."

Done. End of conversation. It was clear she did not want to talk about it anymore. I was floored. How had I come up with the exact name of the town where Jordan would go to feel safe? We both knew she had never mentioned the place before. Had that tiny detail of a name somehow jumped out of *her* mind into *my own*?

WHAT'S IN A NAME?

Was this slip coincidence? Chance? I was convinced that I had never even *heard* the name before, but *might* Jordan have mentioned it earlier in our earlier work together? Had we both failed to register a prior exchange in our explicit memory (Bucci, 2011)? If so, was Tuckahoe simply a memory lapse due to "selective attention" or "preconscious communication" (Kantrowitz, 2001) typically associated with intricately entwined neural systems of repression and dissociation (Schoore, 2003)? Or, had I perhaps heard the name on TV that morning and linguistically commingled it with Timbuktu?

Certainly these rational explanations would conveniently allay other disquieting possibilities, but as Jordan's treatment progressed I was perturbed by a sequence of *further* unexplainable coincidences, leading me to believe that some form of "psychic resonance" was unfolding between us. Skeptical as I was initially about my Tuckahoe slip, I became increasingly convinced that it served a *relational* function between us—as an *action* of an unconscious communication.

Before further elaborating this relational view of Psi and recounting subsequent uncanny clinical exchanges, I outline the position of Psi phenomena within the traditions of psychoanalysis, neuroscience, parapsychological research, and quantum physics.

PSYCHOANALYSIS AND TELEPATHY

Historical Views of Telepathy: To Believe or Not to Believe?

The paranormal or occult has historically generated dichotomized responses ranging from cynicism and skepticism, on one hand, to fascination and unbridled "New Age" conviction,

on the other. Within Freudian-based psychoanalysis, long-standing skepticism about telepathy stems from its stigmatized association with Psi phenomena—including extrasensory perception (ESP), precognition, clairvoyance, and psychokinesis.

Along with the dawn of psychoanalysis in late 19th-century Europe, the materialist worldview strongly asserted the need to separate science and reason from religion and superstition. The Newtonian-based scientific view, “mind equals brain,” asserts that consciousness and thought processes are reducible to warm tissue functions and neural processes. Research into seemingly “illusory” psychic phenomena has for decades been condemned as fraudulent or scandalous (Alcock, 1998; Wiseman, 1997).

While Jung challenged this worldview with notions of the “collective unconscious”⁵ (Jung, 1954/1959), “synchronicity”⁶ (Jung, 1952/1969), and the relationship between consciousness and matter (Jung, 1911-12/1952/1967), Freud largely upheld the positivist worldview of his time and distanced himself from such “dangerous expeditions” (Brabant, Falzeder, & Giampieri-Deutsch, 1992, p. 274). Freud’s primary focus—establishing psychoanalysis as a new and respectable science—required him to dissociate psychoanalysis from both psychical research and the highly criticized Spiritualist movement of the 19th century (Freud, 1921, 1953; Massicotte, 2014). His own curiosity about the occult persisted, however, resulting in an intermittent fascination with thought transference (Freud, 1901, 1919, 1921, 1922) that is well documented in his posthumously published correspondence with Ferenczi (Brabant et al., 1992; Ferenczi, 1932).

While *publicly* decrying so-called occult psychological phenomena, Freud was *privately* conducting his own psychical experiments with Ferenczi to explore the outer limits of unconscious communication⁷ (Jones, 1961). In his 1921 paper “Psychoanalysis and Telepathy,” Freud stated, “It is no longer possible to brush aside the study of so-called occult facts ... [or] mental faculties in which, until now, we did not believe” (p. 56). In “Dreams and Occultism,” Freud (1933) declared, “There remains a strong balance of probability in favour of thought transference as a fact” (p. 43), and in a reported interview with Cornelius Tabori in 1935, he concluded,

I believe that telepathy is a psychical event in one man causing a similar psychical event in another man. It can be presumed that the connection between these two psychological phenomena is physical—perhaps similar to the receiver and the speaking tube of a telephone. (as cited in Clark, 1982, p. 496)

Although still wedded to the mechanical metaphor of the telephone, Freud’s early speculations about telepathy reverberate with contemporary notions of nonverbal, unformulated, dissociated, subsymbolic, implicit, right-brain, mirror neuronal, and sensorial forms of attunement. Let us consider some key historical approaches to nonverbal attunement.

⁵ A pre-existing, inherited part of the unconscious.

⁶ An acausal connection between two or more psycho-physical phenomena.

⁷ See Jones’s account of Freud assuming the role of medium and attempting to capture the thoughts of both his daughter and Ferenczi.

Regression and Psychoanalytic Traditions of “Tuning-In”

A number of psychoanalytic thinkers have developed individualized methods for tuning in to nonverbal unconscious material through the cultivation of shared, trance-like hypnogogic states. Freud's (1912) initial model of regression encouraged free association and the analyst's “evenly suspended attention” (p. 111) aimed at “catch[ing] the drift” of the patient's unconscious with his own unconscious (Freud, 1923, p. 239). Ferenczi (1932) furthered this with his interest in mutuality and the “dialogue of unconsciousness” (p. 84). Bion (1962) advanced notions of the “container” and “alpha” function, exploring encoded communication of the group unconscious (Bion, 1959) and the concept of “O”—“the unknown and the unknowable” (Bion, 1970, p. 27). Winnicott conceived of the “squiggle game” (Winnicott, 1971) and “potential” and “transitional” space (Winnicott, 1975), and Searles (1973) developed “symbiotic relatedness” and the dissolution of boundaries. More recently, Ogden (1997) explored “reverie” and its dynamic interplay between subjectivity and intersubjectivity; Ferro (2006) extended both Bion's concept of the “waking dream thought” and Ogden's reverie; Bollas (2002) “drifts” into the emergence of the “unthought known” (Bollas, 1987) or the “receptive unconscious” (Bollas, 1992). Stern (1997) delved into the embeddedness of “unformulated experience”; and Bromberg (1996) guided us into a “twilight space, in which “the impossible becomes possible” (p. 520).

Recent advances highlight the analyst's body and five senses as acute vehicles of attunement: Levine's (1997) Somatic Experiencing, Ogden et al.'s (2006) Sensorimotor Psychotherapy, Bosnak's (2003) “embodied imagination,” and Sletvold's (2014) “embodied experience.”

Each of these methods entails actively tuning in to unconscious material beyond words whether somatically or imaginatively, “listening with a different ear,” or “shifting [attention] from the latent to the virtual” (Ferro, 2003, p. 1067). So why within psychoanalysis the need to persist with the divide between these methods of attunement and possible paranormal or telepathic attunement?

Psychoanalytic Resistance to Psi Phenomena

Continuing Freud's legacy, many psychoanalysts remain reluctant to consider the plausibility of Psi experiences for fear of being discredited or associated with pseudoscience or parapsychology's long history of fraudulent claims. Yet growing public fascination with the paranormal and mysticism (McTaggart, 2002) suggests the likelihood that anomalous experiences sooner or later find their way into the consulting room. Many therapists report synchronistic experiences such as the phone ringing and knowing who is calling before answering it, or a former patient popping into one's mind days before she calls to return to treatment. Some patients recount dreams the contents of which mirror exact events that take place in their therapist's private life, and more often than we may realize, images/words (such as *Tuckahoe*) break through with uncanny timing and exactitude. This preponderance of reports (Mayer, 2007) can no longer be dismissed as coincidence or magical thinking.

As Western therapists, we are trained to listen for magical thinking as signs of psychopathology (Cardena, Lynn, & Krippner, 2014; Evrard, 2014). Patients' uncanny experiences are often categorized as wishes, fantasies, or signs of schizophrenia. Although vigilance about disguised psychopathology is important, cultural, religious, and political variables (such as Western cultural bias toward separateness and independence) influence whether “altered” states are

viewed as other “realities” or as pathological states (Cardeña et al., 2014, p. 419)—for example, in India the diagnosis of multiple personality disorder is assigned 0.015% (Adityanjee, Raju, & Khandelwal, 1989) compared with an astounding 10% in the United States (Bliss & Jeppsen, 1985, as cited in Cardeña et al., 2014), suggesting a greater tolerance for changing states of consciousness.

What deeper resistances might fortify this mistrust of Psi? Fear of the unknown? Loss of control? Fear of merger or boundary-loss (Loewald, 1978)? Nakedness? If minds are interpenetrable, are there no limits to “seeing” inside one another? Does telepathy trigger archaic, primal fears of being taken over, controlled, colonized, or even harmed (Tart, 1984)? Or might we fear descent into regressive childlike states or terrors (Eisenbud, 1946)? Perhaps it is our sense of individuality and creativity that is threatened, imagining the uniqueness of our imagination as a collapsed by-product of cross-fertilized minds. Some resistance might even linger from the classical belief in analytic omniscience rather than viewing analytic coparticipation as an unpredictable, dynamic interplay between two interconnected, mutually influential minds.

Given the evidence supporting the existence of Psi (Bem & Honorton, 1994; Radin, 2006), a lack of curiosity or dismissive attitude leads one to suspect some intellectual/emotional threat, including the possibility of unconscious envy toward those who *do* experience this heightened form of empathic receptivity. Whatever the resistances, notions of the uncanny stir unsettling fears of the unknown that for psychoanalysts represent “the *other* dark continent of psychological inquiry, rivaling female sexuality as the feared unknown, evoking anxiety and avoidance, or a rush to judge and pathologize, rather than to explore and learn” (Rosenbaum, 2011, p. 60).

Psychoanalytic Literature on Telepathy and the Uncanny

Contrary to the Jungian tradition (Cambray, 2009), early Freudian-based acknowledgment of uncanny phenomena remains comparatively sparse (Devereux, 1953; Eisenbud, 1946; Farrell, 1983; Ferenczi, 1932, 1949; Freud, 1901, 1919, 1921, 1922). While the area of telepathic dreams (*nocturnal* uncanny transmissions) has garnered considerable psychoanalytic interest (Eshel, 2006; Freud, 1922; Ullman, 2003), despite its mixed reputation of respect and repudiation (Devereux, 1953), comparatively little has been reported until recently on uncanny transmissions occurring during *wakefulness* (Allik, 2003; Altman, 2002, 2007; Bass, 2001, 2004; Bollas, 2001; Bromberg, 2011; Davies, 2004; Eshel, 2006, 2010; Harris, 2004b; Lazar, 2001; Mayer, 2007; Rosenbaum, 2011; Suchet, 2004; Tennes, 2007).

Most notable among these is Mayer’s (2007) exhaustive investigation, which stretches our theoretical imagination and is the first extended work to explore the relevance of the uncanny in psychotherapy and psychoanalysis. Jolted into research by the uncanny retrieval of her daughter’s lost harp, Mayer investigates multiple examples of respected analysts’ clinical experiences of “extraordinary knowing.” Especially featured is Robert Stoller’s (Mayer, 2001) posthumously published paper on telepathy (Stoller reportedly dared not publish it himself), in which he describes remarkable incidences of telepathic dreams between himself and his patients, including several patients’ dreams that accurately depict incidents that occurred concurrently in his own personal life.

Mayer chronicled research that challenges conventional understandings of limits to the human mind both during sleep *and* wakefulness. By citing studies by the Princeton Engineering Anomalies Research Laboratory, she advanced the link between

psychoanalysis and physics, introducing mind-matter studies and exploring “remote perception” (transmission of information across distances without conventional forms of contact) and “remote viewing” (method of “seeing” impressions about a distant target, used by the Department of Defense and CIA Intelligence).

Although these reports have evoked criticism from some academics (e.g., Odling-Smee, 2007), Mayer’s book has nevertheless captured the interest of many academics and was endorsed by Freeman Dyson, one of the great physicists and thinkers of our time; Philip Bromberg (2011) speculated that Mayer’s book “could well hold the future of psychoanalysis between its covers” (p. 137).

NEUROBIOLOGY CONFRONTS TELEPATHY

The integration of science has been crucial to psychoanalytic theorizing since Freud’s earliest integration of biology. Today, findings from neuroscientific research and neuroimaging technology (Berlin, 2011; Gallese, 2006; McGilchrist, 2009; Schore, 2003) join discoveries in quantum physics (Bohr, 1972; Heisenberg, 1958/1999, 1979) and social psychology (Bem, 2011) in laying the foundation for new theories of unconscious communication that defy rational explanations and conventional science (Bass, 2001, 2004; Bromberg, 2011).

Clinical reports of telepathic communication present a problem for neurobiologists because they challenge traditionally upheld scientific boundaries of space and time by allegedly occurring not only *during* sessions but also *in between* sessions and even *outside* the therapist’s office (e.g., telepathic dreams between therapist and patient occurring at night). Since these nonlocal phenomena transcend recognized material *sensory* cues (Schlitz, 2004)—even implicit, unconscious physiological perceptions—they transgress the dominantly held Newtonian-based theory of mind that *brain and mind must be one and the same* (Damasio, 2005; Panksepp & Biven, 2012). These nonlocal experiences are *nonphysical* in nature and thus cannot easily be reduced to theories based on neural function.

Neurobiologists continue to search for logical explanations for exceptional experiences (e.g., the brainstem awakening the thalamus and cortex), but these experiences challenge accepted models of the mind, as do explanations for “consciousness,” “subjective experience,” “meaning-making,” “mystical” qualia and “religious experience” (Newberg, 1999). Although neurobiological constructs elegantly describe unconscious communication between two people in the *same physical locality*—such as Buck’s (1994) “conversation between limbic systems,” Schore’s (2003) “right amygdala to right amygdala communication” (p. 227), Bucci’s (1997) “symbolic-subsymbolic communications” (p. 155), and Gallese et al.’s (2007) “mirror neuron systems”—telepathic communication defies these systems when two brains connect *across time and geographical space*.

Headway is also being made in the discovery of neurobiological substrates for the unconscious transmission of affect, memories, and experiences (Berlin, 2011; Mancina, 2006; Schore, 2011) and intergenerational unconscious transmission of trauma (Faimberg, 1988, 2005; Fraiberg, Adelson, & Shapiro, 1975; Harris, 2007; Seligman, 1999), yet neurobiological explanations for the unconscious transmission of discreet pieces of *information* (such as names, like Tuckahoe) have yet to be elaborated.

Can the neurosciences advance our understanding of telepathy? Recent attempts have been made to find neural correlates for the Psi hypothesis using functional neuroimaging techniques

(Acunzo, Evrard, & Rabeyron, 2013) and advanced fusion imaging techniques (simultaneous fMRI, EEG, and magnetoencephalography)—see Persinger (2009), who was partially debunked by Braithwaite (2010). This research (including Venkatasubramanian et al., 2008) is considered controversial by the scientific mainstream but is attracting increasing neuroscientific attention. It remains to be seen whether unconscious forms of communication can indeed be observed and measured within a materially based paradigm bound by concentration on vegetative biology.

SURVEY OF PARAPSYCHOLOGY AND TELEPATHY RESEARCH

Studies of “spontaneous” paranormal phenomena and phenomena produced by mediums/psychics date back to the nineteenth century, but reliability and replicability have been difficult standards to achieve. A brief survey of parapsychological research and its controversies (Alcock, 1990; Cardena et al., 2014; de Peyer, 2014; Hyman, 1985a, 2007; Radin, 1997) reveals a labyrinth of contention far too extensive to enumerate here, in which even meta-analyses (systematic quantitative literature reviews) of telepathy research (e.g., Bem & Honorton, 1994; Honorton, 1985; Honorton et al., 1990; Storm, 2012) have been subjected to extensive criticism (Alcock, 1990, 2003; Hyman, 2007). Even within the field of parapsychology, some researchers concur with the monistic materialistic view (upheld by the neurosciences) that mind is dependent on brain processes, yet others challenge this viewpoint by proposing a dualistic mind-body view that includes a nonphysical dimension of existence (Rhine, Pratt, Stuart, Smith, & Greenwood, 1966; Tart, Puthoff, & Targ, 1979/2002).

Among the most prominent parapsychology research studies over the past 125 years are Rhine’s ESP cards (Rhine et al., 1966), Puthoff and Targ’s ESP studies at Stanford Research Institute (Tart et al., 1979/2002), Dunne and Jahn’s 1976–1999 Princeton Engineering Anomalies Research (Dunne & Jahn, 2003), and hundreds of combined Ganzfeld⁸ thought transference studies (Radin, 2003).

Much of this research has been dismissed as pseudoscience by the mainstream scientific community (Alcock, 1998), even though independently published meta-analyses, such as those by psychologist Honorton (1985) and skeptic Hyman (1985b) (representing opposing viewpoints), report a combined hit rate of 37% where chance expectation is 25% (Radin, 2003). These overall effect sizes are modest and difficult to replicate on demand, perhaps because “natural” telepathy occurs more frequently under circumstances when the “sender” is experiencing heightened physical, psychological, or emotional distress, which is hard to replicate in a laboratory setting.

A leading yet controversial telepathy researcher is Rupert Sheldrake (1981, 2009, 2012; Sheldrake & Smart, 2003), whose theories of “morphic fields,” “morphic resonance,” and the “extended mind” were deemed so provocative by the mainstream scientific community (criticized as pseudoscience and misleading) that his TED talk “The Science Delusion” (Sheldrake, 2013) was removed from distribution on TEDx YouTube’s global Internet conferences. Sheldrake advocates that all human experiences and memories are stored in a nonlocal morphic field (like a universal database) outside the brain. Reminiscent of the ancient Hindu akashic

⁸ Ganzfeld method: controlled experiments in which a “receiver” relaxes in a sensory deprived environment, mentally attempting to correctly name randomly selected video clips “sent” mentally by another person in a distant room.

records (a form of library containing all knowledge of human experience and the history of the cosmos) and Jung's collective unconscious, Sheldrake espouses a living, developing universe with its own inherent memory. He views the mind as fieldlike, extending out beyond the physical brain, and *the brain as receiver of consciousness* much like a radio tuning into radio programs. Sheldrake views telepathy (a natural ability in animal groups) as innately possible among human beings. The human individual is seen as consciousness "honed in" from a greater morphic interconnectedness to compose a unique specificity or *local mind*.

In summary, despite prevailing skepticism, collective findings on telepathy—including mother–infant (Burlingham, 1967) and twin research (Playfair, 2002)—have been significant enough to warrant further investigation, especially since improved laboratory-based methods, standards, and design (Bem & Honorton, 1994; Radin, 2006; Rhine et al., 1966; Schlitz, 2004) have achieved recognition of high quality (Bösch, Steinkamp, & Boller, 2006). With improved research, the Psi hypothesis is becoming harder to dismiss as unscientific or fraudulent (Mishlove, 1980). Parapsychological research is on the increase in accredited universities, is finding its way into high-profile, peer-reviewed academic journals (e.g., Bem, 2011; Storm, Tressoldi, & Di Risio, 2010), and despite its controversy is attracting an expanding roster of highly esteemed academics (e.g., Bem, Honorton, Schooler).

RELEVANCE OF QUANTUM THEORY, ENTANGLEMENT, AND MORPHIC RESONANCE

A century ago, when a collection of creative thinkers came up with groundbreaking theories about how the universe works—including Albert Einstein, Max Planck, and Werner Heisenberg—these ideas inevitably perplexed visionaries in other fields, including Freud and Jung, who were confronted with unanswerable questions about consciousness and the uncanny. As Freud (1912) experimented with the metaphor of the telephone, other scientific innovators transported us from a 17th-century Newtonian world (where elements of the universe were viewed as isolated from one other, separate, and wholly self-contained) into a quantum theory world (led by Born, Bohr, Heisenberg, Pauli, Planck, and Schrödinger) in which "subatomic particles [have] no meaning in isolation, but only in relation with everything else" (McTaggart, 2002, p. xv). The convergence between quantum theory and psychotherapy lies in the grounds that if subatomic particles exist in relation with one another, then so might human minds.

The introduction of Heisenberg's (1927) Uncertainty Principle (the impossibility of measuring position, momentum, and trajectory of a particle simultaneously), the "observer effect" (the act of observing influences the observed), and the advancement of quantum theory during the 1920s and 1930s all significantly impacted the development of psychoanalytic theorizing. As the classical one-person intrapsychic model evolved into an intersubjective two-person model (Aron, 1990) and developed into a model of complex, unpredictable, dynamic systems (Coburn, 2014; Galatzer-Levy, 2009; Harris, 2013; Piers, 2005; Seligman, 2005; Thelen, 2005), relaxed definitions from quantum theory have increasingly been applied to the therapeutic dyad (Atmanspacher, Römer, & Walach, 2002; Bass, 1997, 2001; Eshel, 2002; Gargiulo, 2010; Sucharov, 1992).

If particles in the quantum world communicate instantaneously with one another, jumping from one place to another without seeming to need to travel in between, would it not follow that patients' and therapists' minds would be capable of doing the same thing? Telepathy's localized,

directional metaphor of transmission and reception would therefore be more accurately described by *resonant interconnectedness* or “entanglement” (Radin, 2006; Schrödinger, 1935) in which minds can affect one another and information is instantaneously accessible by all through *resonant immersion in a ubiquitous, omni-present field*.

Entanglement metaphors view telepathy as quantum fluctuations exchanged between two hypothetically entangled minds, each mind being permanently altered by this entanglement (Radin, 2006). In quantum entanglement, particles that have previously interacted with each other maintain a connection as pairs and can seemingly interact with each other spontaneously over incredible distances throughout space and time. Quantum physicists are finding that “the effects of [these] microscopic entanglements ‘scale up’ into our macroscopic world” (p. 2), suggesting that human beings are part of a vastly interconnected universe or “unbroken wholeness” (Bohm, 1980), as explored by Jung and Pauli (2001) in their collaborations between depth psychology and quantum physics.

By applying these concepts from quantum physics to the psychoanalytic encounter (Atmanspacher et al., 2002; Jung & Pauli, 2001), are we perhaps going too far? Should we leave the enigma of the uncanny to poets, artists, philosophers, and mystics? Although we must be wary of reifying science as the new “God,” there is a striking convergence between quantum theory and ancient Vedanta and Buddhist concepts of “universal consciousness” (Goswami, 2008). A consistent theoretical explanation for telepathy has yet to be found, but a compelling argument can be made for a correlation between quantum theory and entangled mental states.

THEORETICAL DISCUSSION: WAS TUCKAHOE COINCIDENCE, NEURAL PROCESS, OR TELEPATHY?

Alicia’s house in Tuckahoe had represented a temporary “relational sanctuary” for Jordan growing up. It provided a concrete *solution* to the binary alternatives of entrapment in helpless submission or permanent exile from her family. My Tuckahoe slip offered Jordan an image of relational security right at the moment when her fears of abandonment were most heightened. It also provided associations of independence and agency for Jordan, and it served to divert what might have become an intersubjective collision between us in the treatment.

Whether coincidence, telepathic, or simply drawn from implicit memory, the sense memory or “acoustic image” (Kugler, 1982) of Tuckahoe provided an “interpretation” (Schwartz-Salant, 1988) that was evocative, effective, and more linguistically precise than any intervention I could have dreamt up consciously. It gave symbolic recognition to a part of Jordan that had previously been outside her conscious awareness—the capacity to take care of herself while sustaining meaningful attachments.

If not simply coincidence, this slip was an example of the human intuitive instrument working sublimely on automatic. Yet how was the name Tuckahoe, such a “discreet entity” (Bucci, 1997, p. 166), stored, plucked, and transferred with such precision, speed, and timely exactitude? New technologies in the cognitive sciences are revealing the sophistication of neural processes and mirror neuron systems, confirming that unconscious processing occurs at hundreds of milliseconds quicker than conscious awareness (Berlin, 2011; Kahneman, 2011). Will these technologies eventually reveal how one person’s brain can spontaneously replicate so precisely the experience of an other?

Using Sheldrake's vision, I could say the image of Tuckahoe (with its link to a strong affective, archetypal longing for a sanctuary) spread out beyond the confines of Jordan's head, resulting in the potential for someone else closely affectively attuned (me) to telepathically access it. In the spirit of this metaphor, I "borrowed a thought" from a unified field of shared knowledge within *and* beyond our dyadic intimacy.

"TELEPATHIC BLINDSIGHT"

If telepathic channels exist, might anomalous cognitions occur infrequently due to some inhibiting factor or barrier that prevents us from tuning in to conscious awareness of this alternative wavelength?

New research demonstrates that even stimuli that are presented *subliminally*, such as masked fearful human faces (Berlin, 2011), modulate neural activity in the brain and generate emotional responses outside of conscious awareness. "Blindsight" experiments on patients with lesions in the primary visual cortex demonstrate that patients who are blind "can perceive visual stimuli even though they are not conscious of doing so" (Berlin, 2011, p. 8, footnote 3). "Affective blindsight" experiments ("blindsmell" and "blindtouch") involve the brain similarly registering olfactory or somatic stimuli while unconsciously *filtering out* the stimuli from conscious perception.

I propose that if the brain can bypass (or tune out) *sensory* stimuli (as in affective blindsight), it might also have a mechanism for bypassing *other* forms of incoming data or stimuli, such as other people's thoughts, feelings, sensations, images, histories, and experiences. Let us call this *telepathic blindsight*. Perhaps human beings are more porous to one another's experiences than we realize; the material instrument of the brain registers these stimuli on a neural level yet filters out these data from consciousness in order to survive.

Psychics, or those with ESP, might have neural filter systems that *leak*, allowing greater *conscious access* to these stimuli. For some, leakage might be triggered by dreams, music, visual imagery, memories, prayer, rapture, daydreams, delirium, smell, and other sensory cues. What personal variables might predispose people to such leakage? Heightened stress or early childhood trauma (as in Jordan's case) might install a hard-wiring of hypervigilance and heightened receptivity (Frankel, 2004). For others, early immersion in nonverbal, creative/artistic modes of expression might develop a correlation between creativity and psychic attunement (Carson, Peterson, & Higgins, 2003).

So why would our species need to block Psi receptivity from conscious awareness? Perhaps without this filter the constant influx of stimuli would overwhelm the system, preventing us from focusing on worldly matters and the survival of the human species. Would we be aware of absolutely everything, everywhere, all the time? How could we have an experience of selfhood and preservation of social norms? Perhaps our brains fine-tune certain frequencies, like radio stations in a vast field of static, for the sake of preservation of humankind. Certainly, those living with ongoing porousness run the risk of developing paranoia, fear of being taken over, becoming transparent, or even believing they can harm others with their thoughts. Clinicians faced with uncanny porousness in their patients must survive such potential fears of fusion, merger, or power struggles, lest iatrogenic anxiety contribute to impasse or destructive enactments (see Spiegelman & Mansfield, 1996).

FURTHER CLINICAL EXAMPLES: COINCIDENCE OR TELEPATHIC INTERCONNECTEDNESS?

Whose Permission?

Following many months of writing, researching, and noting further anomalies occurring between us, I wanted to ask Jordan's permission to publish this paper. Jordan was doing fairly well in her life, and by this time I believed she would not object and we could work through any possible complications. I disguised her identity and felt prepared to abandon the project altogether if she seemed uncomfortable. My hunch was that she would be intrigued and that opening this discussion would actually enhance her treatment (which it ended up doing in complex ways).

The same week that I decided to ask her permission, she called me to quite uncharacteristically request an extra session. She wanted to discuss an ethical dilemma—whether to ask her *own* clients (in whose homes she had previously worked) for permission to photograph interiors of their homes for a book that *she* wanted to write! She had never before mentioned working on a book, and she had no conscious knowledge that I was writing about *her*. Once more this synchronicity amazed me, as if our minds were somehow entrained. I have often wondered about the unconscious effects of writing about our patients, believing it has inevitable impact on the transference–countertransference field in ways we might not yet understand.

Since Jordan was struggling with her *own* issue of seeking permission that day, I withheld my request and attempted to listen to her dilemma unintrusively. Several weeks later, I finally did ask her permission, which she duly granted, and we read an earlier version of this paper together in my office.

Whose Dream?

Months earlier, prior to reading the paper, one Monday morning Jordan presented a disturbing dream. In the dream, she woke up in the middle of the night to the sound of her husband groaning. She got out of bed and went to the bathroom, where she found George sitting on the toilet “freaking out,” losing a lot of blood. When Jordan awakened the next morning, she was upset and unsure if this had been real or just a nightmare. She asked George if it had really happened. George reassured her that it was just a bad dream and that despite all his medical problems, thankfully rectal bleeding had never been among them! They laughed.

What Jordan had no way of knowing (at least consciously) was that on that same night, I *myself* had woken up in the middle of the night to sounds of groaning coming from my *own* bathroom, where I found my *own* husband sitting on the toilet in the midst of an unprecedented, frightening, and identical episode of bleeding. This had never happened to my husband before (a condition that has since been resolved), but the events were identical to those depicted in Jordan's dream. I listened that day, tightly gripping the arms of my chair, as Jordan replayed my own waking nightmare.

This convergence brought the feeling of boundarilessness between us to a new pitch. I said nothing on that day of my own experience, but I silently wondered if I had somehow emitted to Jordan my life-threatening situation. Had she unconsciously tuned into my fear or picked up on my absent preoccupation due to my own life issues (Eshel, 2006)? Was she hyperattuned due to

fear of neglect and abandonment (Eshel, 2006; Servadio, 1955), calling me back through the “search engine” of her dream?

Each of the three examples presented represents a distinct form of Psi experience: *Tuckahoe*—telepathic word/image transmission; *permission*—synchronicity of thought/ideas; *dream*—telepathic dream embodiment of the analyst’s experience. When examined as a group, the cumulative effect of these shared experiences coalesce into a repetitive pattern of transmission for which there is no material explanation.

CONCLUSIONS

Having considered various metaphors for understanding these uncanny transmissions from the disciplines of psychoanalysis, neuroscience, quantum physics, and parapsychology, I conclude with some important clinical implications of Psi.

First, the likelihood is that these phenomena occur more frequently within the clinical dyad than we realize (Mayer, 2007).

Second, moments of uncanny relatedness offer patient and analyst an unusual opportunity for meaningful connection—a unique sense of being known by another across a vast, alienating universe. Jordan and my uncanny connection provided an underlying “glue” during our worst moments of interpersonal fracture, offering access to another level of each other’s subjectivity and assuaging terrors of alienation, separation, and existential aloneness. By tuning down sensory input, the clinician’s cultivation of states of reverie and meditation might tune up receptivity to otherwise imperceptible data about patients. Perhaps telepathic sensibility should be added to the psychotherapist’s skill set of methods of empathic attunement.

Third, if the minds of patient and therapist intermingle on conscious, unconscious, and *uncanny* levels, we should be more mindful of the potential influence of our countertransference thoughts and feelings (even *in-between* sessions) over our patients’ well-being.

Fourth, although patients’ and clinicians’ belief systems about Psi will vary, the way in which the clinician handles these convergences and differences (with transparency/acceptance/neutrality/judgment) will greatly affect whether the patient feels pathologized or safe in the therapeutic relationship. The therapist’s attitude toward Psi might even affect the likelihood and frequency of its occurrence. Openness about anomalous phenomena can strengthen the therapeutic connection, just as rejection or subtle dismissal of a patient’s anomalous beliefs can cause humiliation and the bankrupting of deep longings to be known.

CLINICAL POSTSCRIPT

Jordan did go on her photographic retreat and produced some magnificent photographs. Now in her 7th year of treatment, it is paradoxical that despite our seamlessly intimate nonverbal level of connection, our day-to-day verbal transactions still fall into clumsy misattunements. I believe that throughout her life Jordan has longed to feel truly read by someone. I have often wondered how it must feel that I so grossly misread her sometimes yet get her with such inexplicable accuracy at other times. When our verbal communication defaults, we seem to draw strength from another frequency of connection that transcends the conventions

of time and space. This porousness can sometimes feel unnerving and overly exposing to each of us.

As we discussed this paper together, it became clear that the symbolic meaning of Tuckahoe meant far less to Jordan than the simple fact that I pulled the name from her internal world without her having to say it out loud. Jordan was more interested in why I had/hadn't shared my uncanny experiences with her when they happened, explaining that having access to my internal process felt good and allowed her to feel closer to me. Her question brought home the unbidden vulnerability and exposure that uncanny transmissions can thrust upon both patient *and* analyst. What was my comfort level with this porousness between us, and how does any clinician navigate the complexities of deliberate self-disclosure when boundaries feel so muddled?

After finishing reading the paper together, I asked Jordan what she thought of the name that I had picked for her. She replied in her typical throwaway tone, "Oh, that doesn't surprise me—only a handful of people in my life know that if I was ever going to have a child, Jordan was the name I was gonna choose, since it works for both boys and girls."

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